The Rapture of Caanan

By Sheri Reynolds

"Tell me the story, Nanna," I used to beg my grandma, leaning against her in the porch swing.

"You don't want to hear that old story, Herman shouldn'ta never put it in that sermon."

"Please tell it, you tell it better than Grandpa."

INTRODUCTION

Grandpa Herman, founder of The Church of Fire and Brimstone and God's Almighty Baptizing Wind, has a flock to tend to -- his congregation, where some mimic Herman's steadfast and unnerving faith, and some who occasionally stray from the righteous path. And perhaps the most surprising stray of all is his granddaughter, Ninah. Fourteen-year-old Ninah, who finds difficulty in controlling her first adolescent stirrings, manages somehow convince herself the things she does with her prayer partner, James, is nothing more than learning about Jesus's love through each other. And once the community finds out, the whole system of the Church is shocked to a halt. "The wages of sin is death," says Grandpa Herman. The rapture has come. The Rapture of Caanan by Sheri Reynolds.

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My grandpa Herman Langston was founder and preacher of The Church of Fire and Brimstone and God's Almighty Baptizing Wind. I think when he was trying to come up with a name for it, he just couldn't make up his mind, so he put all his ideas together and nobody said a thing.

"We've all sinned in the eyes of God, My own wife Leila turned her back on God. She saw her own mother engaging in sins of the flesh and did not tell. And on the say that her own mother pulled out a rifle and shot her father through the back so she could live in sin with a boy young enough to be her son, did she call out to God? No."

I don't think that anybody know exactly how Grandpa Herman came up with his brand of Christianity. In the summers, we worked the fields all day. By the time supper came, we were so weary that even breathing felt like work. I had fallen asleep at the table.

"Did you say your prayers young lady?" Mamma asked. "Before you fell asleep?"

"I didn't mean to fall asleep."

"Don' talk back. Did you say your prayers Ninah?"

"No, ma'am."

Then Mama led me to bed. When she pulled back my covers, there were cockleburs and sandspurs scattered all over my sheets. I knew there would be. I couldn't sleep for a long time. The prickles were sticking in my back. I guess I deserved it.

Sometimes the children could get permission to go horseback riding. One afternoon we were out in the woods, with me and Mustard and James on one horse. The girls always got sandwiched between the boys, and that day I was protected by Mustard from the front and James from the back.

"Let's take then to the top and run down fast."

"Don't do it Mustard," James warned from behind me.

But Mustard kicked the mare and she took off.

"Ninah, tell him to stop."

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But I didn't want him to stop. It wasn't that I wanted the horse to get hurt. I was too busy trying to memorize the way James' legs felt around my backside, hanging on, the way his arms felt buckled around my middle.

All that winter James and I came together as prayer partners. We prayed like never before.

One Saturday night, we went to the choir loft. James led me through the little swinging door, and we knelt on the second row.

"Lord, I've been praying and praying about this, and I know you've given Ninah something to say to me."

""I'm here, God. I've been praying for this too. I want to be the one to give James your special instructions for his life."

"Lord, I'm not sure that I'm feeling you right, but I want to."

And then he kissed me like a waterfall, and I kept my mouth wide open.

"Ninah, this can't be right. We have to pray."

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"God, I think we're getting mixed signals. You have to lead us cause we don't' know what to do."

And then I kissed him.

"Ninah, we have to pray!"

"That's what we're doing."

I ran my lips across his eyelid. And then God spoke. Really fast. And then I knew him like I'd never known him before.

Grandpa Herman gave another sermon, an angry one about Hell.

"Fornication is ground for being thrown out of the community. Fornication is grounds for being tossed sidelong off the streets of Jasper, through the Pearly Gates, and into the Great Lake of Fire."

I peeked over at James, who sat at the other side of the table. He was staring blankly. I tried and tried to will him to look at me, but he didn't. Inside, I felt the worst lonely I'd ever known.

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We were on the far side of the barn, stretched out on our backs, looking up at dark sky pocked with clouds.

"Do you ever worry that what we do sometimes during prayers could be considered…fornicating?"

"No." I lied. "What we're doing is different. It's just a part of prayer."

I didn't know what to do. I'd taken something beautiful like our prayers and turned them into something horrible – just so I could keep feeling good. And I didn't feel good.

I knew that I was probably having a baby. Then I got to thinking that maybe it was Jesus' baby – because if we really hadn't been sinning and had only been knowing Jesus through each other, then it couldn't be anything but Jesus'

I decided I'd better tell James about it.

"I'm, you now, with child."

"Ninah, you can't be."

"I am."

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"Oh hell, fire and damnation. Ninah, they're gonna kill us."

"Even if it's Jesus' baby?"

"It's my baby Ninah. Not Jesus'."

"But if I was knowing Jesus through you, then you were just the vehicle."

"Oh, for God's sake, Ninah."

"You mean you don't think it was Jesus – when we touched?"

"No. It was me and you, sinning like crazy."

"But even at first?"

"It was me and you."

"If you knew we weren't being Jesus for each other, then why'd you deep doing it?"

"I didn't think God would let it happen. I didn't know something so awful could come from something so nice."

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I saw Mustard stretched out on a drag, already asleep even though it was barely dark. I peeked into the barn, calling James, but he wasn't there either.

"Did you find him?"

"No."

"Well, James probably snuck off to the pond to cool down."

"You think so? He was expecting me."

"Yeah, maybe he forgot."

"Well, I'm real worried about him."

Ten minutes later, I was sitting behind Mustard on a horse, trotting through the woods. I was almost sure James wasn't swimming.

Mustard stopped the horse near an old tree that had fallen into the pond. I hopped off right away, climbed into the tree.

"James."

Mustard bolted towards me. By the time he reached me, I had already picked up the piece of rope I found running along the length of the tree.

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Mustard grabbed the rope behind me, and we both pulled, and Mustard told me it might just be a sunken boat and I cried because the other end was too heavy to be the kind of boat you can float in a pond.

Finally we pulled a massive piece of tree out of the water. I could see a body tied to it. I stood on the trunk looking down at James, his mouth gaping. I was suddenly still, and I didn't hear Mustard say, "Give me the rope," until he'd already pulled it from my hands.

Some people say you can't change history, but that isn't entirely true. We did it at Fire and Brimstone. James didn't take his own life. He drowned on a hot night, caught on a root in the bottom of the pond. Nobody ever mentioned that he was tethered to that sunken tree with thick deliberate knots.

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AWARD HISTORY

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